



Grade 6
General
English Language Arts

Directions:

On the following pages of your practice test booklet are questions for the Grade 6 *Nebraska Student-Centered Assessment System (NSCAS) General English Language Arts* practice test.

Read these directions carefully before beginning the test.

This practice test will include several different types of questions. Some questions are based on a passage. Multiple choice questions will ask you to select an answer from among four choices. Multiple select questions will ask you to select multiple correct answers from among five or more answer choices. For some questions, there may be two parts, Part A and Part B, where each part has a multiple choice or multiple select question. Some questions will ask you to construct an answer by following the directions given.

For all questions:

- Read each question carefully and choose the best answer.
- You may use scratch paper to make notes.
- Be sure to answer ALL the questions.

Read the passage.

This story is based on the real-life account of Maud Marston, a journalist from Kearney, Nebraska. She was the only reporter to have an interview with Nellie Bly during her journey around the world.

Chasing Nellie Bly

- 1 Maud rushed into the house, shutting the heavy wooden door behind her. The wind whipped and the snow flurried outside, but inside it was cozy and warm with a fire blazing in the fireplace and the smell of warm bread drifting from the kitchen.
- 2 “Mama, Papa!” Maud called out as she kicked off her boots by the front door. “You are not going to believe this!”
- 3 Maud’s parents greeted her with a smile as she rounded the corner into the kitchen. “What is it, darlin’?” Papa asked, seeing the mixture of excitement and worry on his daughter’s face.
- 4 “You know that story that I have been hoping for, the one where I will get to interview the famous Nellie Bly about her trip around the world?” she queried. “Well, I got it!”
- 5 “That is terrific news!” Mama and Papa said in unison as they reached across the table to squeeze Maud’s hand.
- 6 “But I do not understand,” Mama continued, sounding puzzled. “Why do you seem a little worried?”
- 7 “I was supposed to meet up with her train in western Nebraska,” Maud explained, “and then ride with her across the state, interviewing her as we traveled east toward Omaha. But now because of snow on the tracks, they have switched her to the Santa Fe line, so she will not be going through Nebraska at all. I will never get another chance like this. Never!”
- 8 Papa smiled and winked at Maud. “Now if I know my **headstrong** daughter, she is not going to let a little detail like that get in her way. You will think of something; I am sure of it!”
- 9 That night, Maud tossed and turned in her bed, her mind spinning with wild nightmares about a journalism career in ruins. She tried to calm her thoughts and think about pleasant things. She **mused** about nature and the beauty of the Earth to forget about her troubles. But as soon as that topic entered her mind, she pictured the snow piling high on the tracks and blocking Nellie’s path to Nebraska.

- 10** At some point during the night, Maud must have drifted off to sleep because the next thing she knew, she was waking up in her warm bed to the aroma of hotcakes and bacon drifting from the kitchen. The smell immediately made her think of the time she and Papa went to Kansas City together for one of his business trips. She could still taste those delicious hotcakes dripping with syrup and that crunchy bacon and . . .
- 11** Suddenly Maud sprang out of bed, pulling her robe and slippers on as quickly as possible. She had the idea of a lifetime!
- 12** "Papa, Mama," Maud called as she darted down the stairs in the old farmhouse, "you are not going to believe what that smell of bacon and hotcakes just inspired me to realize!"
- 13** Papa and Mama laughed at Maud's excitement and her slightly disheveled appearance. "What is it, Maud? We are on pins and needles waiting!" Mama said, giving her daughter a good-morning hug.
- 14** "Nellie's train goes right through Kansas City. I could take the train from here to Omaha and transfer down to Kansas City and meet up with her!"
- 15** "That is a brilliant idea!" Papa replied. "But how did the smell of hotcakes and bacon cause you to think of that?" he asked, curious.
- 16** "Thanks to you, Papa, and that business trip breakfast I ate with you in Kansas City years ago, the idea just flowed into my brain along with that smell of sizzling bacon!" Maud explained. "If you are up for a return trip, I would love it if you rode with me to Kansas City!"
- 17** "Well, if you two are going to make this morning's train, you should get a move on!" Mama prodded them along, knowing that Maud still had to gather her things and make herself presentable before she left. "And in honor of its memory-boosting power, I will wrap up some bacon-rolled hotcakes for you to eat on the road!"

1. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

How do Papa and Mama feel about Maud in the story?

- A. worried that Maud is not getting enough sleep
- B. happy that Maud is safe from the snow storm outside
- C. proud of Maud's ability to think of a way to meet Nellie Bly
- D. confused about why Maud is so eager to interview Nellie Bly

Part B

Which detail from the story BEST supports the answer to Part A?

- A. Maud called out as she kicked off her boots by the front door. "You are not going to believe this!"
 - B. Maud's parents greeted her with a smile as she rounded the corner into the kitchen.
 - C. "What is it, Maud? We are on pins and needles waiting!" Mama said, giving her daughter a good-morning hug.
 - D. "That is a brilliant idea!" Papa replied.
2. What is the MAIN conflict in the story?
- A. Maud is worried her journalism career will never work.
 - B. Nellie Bly's train is no longer going through Nebraska.
 - C. Nellie Bly will not talk to any other journalists than Maud.
 - D. Maud's parents think she is overreacting about the weather.

3. Which detail from the story gives the BEST clue to the meaning of **headstrong** in paragraph 8?
- A. Papa smiled and winked . . .
 - B. “ . . . she is not going to let a little detail like that get in her way.”
 - C. “You will think of something . . .”
 - D. . . . she pictured the snow piling high on the tracks and blocking Nellie’s path to Nebraska.
4. Why is paragraph 8 important to the development of the story?
- A. It introduces the main problem of the story that Maud will have to face.
 - B. It further illustrates the relationship Maud has with her parents.
 - C. It hints that Maud is a person who will find a way to meet up with Nellie Bly.
 - D. It predicts how Maud will spend the rest of the night tossing and turning in her bed.
5. What is the meaning of **mused** as it is used in paragraph 9?
- A. learned
 - B. remembered
 - C. wondered
 - D. worried

6. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

How does the author BEST develop the point of view of the story?

- A. by describing the actions Maud will take to get to Kansas City
- B. by showing the emotion Mama and Papa feel towards their daughter
- C. by showing Maud's thoughts and worries about missing Nellie Bly
- D. by describing the conversation Maud has with her parents in the kitchen

Part B

Which detail from the story BEST supports the correct answer to Part A?

- A. "What is it, darlin'?" Papa asked, seeing the mixture of excitement and worry on his daughter's face.
- B. The smell immediately made her think of the time she and Papa went to Kansas City together for one of his business trips.
- C. "I could take the train from here to Omaha and transfer down to Kansas City and meet up with her!"
- D. Mama prodded them along, knowing that Maud still had to gather her things and make herself presentable before she left.

7. Which sentence from the story BEST supports the idea that Maud is inspired by Nellie Bly?
- A. “You know that story that I have been hoping for, the one where I will get to interview the famous Nellie Bly about her trip around the world?” she queried.
 - B. “But I do not understand,” Mama continued, sounding puzzled. “Why do you seem a little worried?”
 - C. “But now because of snow on the tracks, they have switched her to the Santa Fe line, so she will not be going through Nebraska at all.”
 - D. That night, Maud tossed and turned in her bed, her mind spinning with wild nightmares about a journalism career in ruins.

8. **This question has two parts. Answer Part A, and then answer Part B.**

Part A

Which sentence BEST states the theme of the story?

- A. Getting what you want takes hard work and a lot of discipline.
- B. Thinking creatively about a problem can often result in a solution.
- C. Getting rest and dreaming can help a person to think more clearly.
- D. Achieving one's goals can often only be done with the help of family.

Part B

Which detail from the story BEST supports the correct answer to Part A?

- A. "That is terrific news!" Mama and Papa said in unison. . .
- B. She tried to calm her thoughts and think about pleasant things.
- C. She had the idea of a lifetime!
- D. "If you are up for a return trip, I would love it if you rode with me to Kansas City!"

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 9. Select the article that correctly completes each sentence.

I was taking a walk in the woods when I saw (**a, an**) elegant female deer standing silently in the distance. The deer was traveling with her young fawn. (**A, The**) fawn quickly hid behind its mother. I was quiet, but I couldn't get close.

- ★ 10. **Mila is writing a report about Abraham Lincoln. Read the paragraphs she found in a book.**

The Lincolns were forced to move from Abraham's birthplace of Kentucky to Perry County, Indiana, due to a land dispute in 1817. There, the family lived on public land in a modest shelter, hunting game and farming a small plot. Abraham's father, Thomas, was eventually able to buy the land.

Thomas' new wife, Sarah, encouraged Abraham to read. It was while growing into manhood that Abraham Lincoln received his formal education—an estimated total of 18 months—a few days or weeks at a time. Reading material was in short supply in the Indiana wilderness. Neighbors recalled how Abraham would walk for miles to borrow a book.

Mila wrote these sentences. Which sentence can she use in her report because it avoids plagiarism?

- A. Books were in short supply in the Indiana wilderness.
- B. In Indiana, the family lived on public land in a modest shelter.
- C. Neighbors recalled that Abraham was a very determined reader.
- D. Abraham received an estimated total of 18 months of formal education.

Read the passage.

A Highway of Water

- 1 In 1849, travelers going from the East Coast to the West Coast of the United States had two choices. They could go by wagon across America's sometimes dangerous prairie land. The other choice was to board a sailing ship in New York bound for California. This route led down the Atlantic Coast, around the tip of South America into the Pacific Ocean, and then north up the Pacific Coast to California. The 15,000 mile journey took months. Severe weather, which is common at the tip of South America where the two oceans meet, could add as much as five months more to the trip.
- 2 Could there be any other way to travel from the Atlantic to the Pacific? The answer was a canal. A canal is a man-made waterway. It provides passage between two natural bodies of water. Think of a canal as a highway of water.
- 3 Panama is a small country connecting North America with South America. At its narrowest part, it is barely fifty miles wide. The Atlantic Ocean is on the eastern side of Panama, and the Pacific Ocean is on the western side. Panama seemed the logical place to build a canal. With a canal in Panama, the trip from New York to California would be 8,000 miles shorter than sailing around South America. Travel time could be three months instead of eight months.
- 4 In 1879, France began to build a canal across Panama. Problems began as soon as construction started. It rained every day, causing the soil to become heavy and gooey. Temperatures climbed as high as 130 degrees. Two diseases, yellow fever and malaria, caused illness or death to the majority of workers. In 1899, France **abandoned** the project.
- 5 The U.S. Congress decided to finish the canal. The U.S. government paid \$40 million to France for the completed work and abandoned equipment. A treaty was signed guaranteeing Panama \$250,000 each year for use of the land. In November 1904, American workers began completion of the Panama Canal.
- 6 American officials wanted to protect workers from disease. An engineer, Frank Stevens, arrived at the work camp in Panama. He began building hospitals as well as water and sewage systems. He supported the camp doctor's efforts to fight mosquitoes, the cause of malaria and yellow fever. More than 100 tons of insect powder was ordered, and crews set about eliminating mosquitoes.

- 7** A system of locks and gates had to be built in the canal to move ships from one ocean to the other. A lock is a giant box made of concrete. A ship must pass through three locks in the Panama Canal. Each lock holds millions of gallons of water. A ship moves into a lock, which is filled with water. Water is pumped into the lock or out of the lock. This raises or lowers the ship to the level of water in the next lock. The gates open, and the ship moves into the next lock.
- 8** By early 1913, the canal was nearly complete. It took several months to fill the canal with water. On September 26, 1913, an old tugboat was the first ship through the canal. Thousands of people watched and cheered. The locks worked perfectly.
- 9** In modern times, more than 15,000 ships make the fifty-mile trip through the canal each year. Each ship that passes through must pay a fee based on its size. A ship called *Radiance of the Seas* paid the largest fee ever, which was \$201,177. The smallest fee was collected in 1928, when Richard Halliburton paid \$0.36 to swim through the canal.
- 10** Time, money, and possibly even lives have been saved as ships use the shorter route from ocean to ocean provided by the canal. The Panama Canal, a highway of water, is a phenomenon.

11. How does paragraph 1 fit into the overall structure of the passage?
- A. It introduces the idea that the only coast-to-coast travel option was by ship.
 - B. It sets up some of the challenges that workers would face in building the Panama Canal.
 - C. It develops the idea that finding a new way to travel around the country was necessary.
 - D. It presents the history of travel in the United States in order to show how travel has changed.
12. What made Panama a logical location for the canal?
- A. The country had enough water to fill each of the locks.
 - B. The country had a narrow part located right between two oceans.
 - C. The country had pleasant weather that made it easy to do construction.
 - D. The country had enough workers and equipment at the canal location.
13. What idea about the canal does the title “A Highway of Water” describe?
- A. it is used frequently
 - B. it contains many cars
 - C. it works quickly and effectively
 - D. it is crowded and disorganized

14. Why did France stop building the canal?

- A. The soil was too dry.
- B. The weather was hot and rainy.
- C. The government of France ran out of money.
- D. The work crews were homesick for their families.

15. The author states that “The Panama Canal, a highway of water, is a phenomenon.”

A phenomenon is something that is remarkable or rare.

Which sentence from the passage BEST supports the idea that the Panama Canal was a phenomenon?

- A. The U.S. government paid \$40 million to France for the completed work and abandoned equipment.
- B. It took several months to fill the canal with water.
- C. Thousands of people watched and cheered.
- D. A ship called *Radiance of the Seas* paid the largest fee ever, which was \$201,177.

16. According to the passage, what is the MAIN benefit of the Panama Canal?

- A. It allows Panama to charge fees in order to use the canal.
- B. It provides a much faster way to travel and transport goods.
- C. It provides many jobs to workers from several countries.
- D. It allows for countries to help each other and work together.

17. What BEST describes the author's purpose in the passage?
- A. to persuade the reader to visit the Panama Canal
 - B. to inform the reader about the history of the Panama Canal
 - C. to describe how the lock and gate system of the canal works effectively
 - D. to argue for the continued construction of canals throughout the world

The items on this page are not passage-based.

- ★ 18. Read the paragraph from Dawson's story.

Troy opened the door to find the **source** of the scratching. He was startled to see his dog Sherman **covered in mud** from head to tail. Troy brought Sherman back inside and then **looked at** the backyard. The gate was locked and Troy saw no **evidence** of digging under the fence. He didn't see mud puddles on the ground, either. It was a mystery.

Dawson wants to use more precise language in his story. Which change should Dawson make?

- A. replace **source** with **cause**
 - B. replace **covered in mud** with **dirty**
 - C. replace **looked at** with **investigated**
 - D. replace **evidence** with **sign**
- ★ 19. Which sentence is punctuated correctly?
- A. My brother, Phil who just returned from Italy said this was his favorite trip so far.
 - B. My brother Phil who just returned from Italy, said this was his favorite trip so far.
 - C. My brother Phil who, just returned from Italy, said this was his favorite trip so far.
 - D. My brother Phil, who just returned from Italy, said this was his favorite trip so far.

The item on this page is not passage-based.

- ★ 20. **Read the first paragraphs of an essay Phoebe is writing.**

My parents think that I should be in bed by no later than 10 p.m. every school night. They think it's very important for me to have a consistent, early bedtime so that I get a good night's sleep. I disagree, because my bedtime has little to do with when I fall asleep.

I agree that it's important for me to sleep well in order to do well the next day. However, I do not fall asleep immediately after my light goes out at 10 p.m. _____ I toss and turn for at least an hour. An early bedtime does not help me sleep more.

Which word, if used in the blank, would BEST help Phoebe connect her sentences?

- A. Also,
- B. Instead,
- C. Meanwhile,
- D. Therefore,

**NSCAS General Grade 6
Practice Test Answer Key
ELA**



Sequence	Key	Points
1	Part A: C Part B: D	2
2	B	1
3	B	1
4	C	1
5	C	1
6	Part A: C Part B: B	2
7	A	1
8	Part A: B Part B: C	2
9	an, The	1
10	C	1
11	C	1
12	B	1
13	C	1
14	B	1
15	C	1
16	B	1
17	B	1
18	C	1
19	D	1
20	B	1